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Ron Carter

Ron Carter has become one of the most accomplished and recorded bassists in all of jazz history. He was born in Ferndale, Michigan on May 4, 1937 and started on cello, later switching to bass when he found classical playing opportunities to be unjustly limited. He gained a degree from the Eastman School of Music and soon found steady work in New York playing with Chico Hamilton, Randy Weston, and Eric Dolphy. After earning a master's degree from the Manhattan School of Music, he began amassing a list of credits that can scarcely be documented. Highlights include his tenure with Miles Davis from 1963-68, the Milestone Jazz Stars, and his own ensembles. He has produced numerous records as a leader, often featuring his cello, piccolo bass and original compositions.

Ron was interviewed in New York City on January 17, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Manhattan and I'm very pleased to have Ron Carter with me, in between sets at the Iridium.

RC: Nice to be here with you.

MR: Can you tell me, very quickly, when you were a child was classical music prevalent in your household?

RC: I think music in general was. I think musicians of my age, my age category all studied classical music because there was no jazz schools, and there were no jazz teachers who would come through a city often enough to make lessons productive. And so we all studied, but the people you studied with were people at local music schools or in the elementary/high school music program, so while classical music was not the primary focus of music in my house, those were the only teachers who were around teaching music, and they were classical players. We played in classical orchestras and classical concerts until such time as we moved on to the next stage of our musical careers.

MR: When you moved to Detroit, was there a healthy jazz scene in Detroit at that time?

RC: Oh yeah. There were three or four major clubs that brought in major acts. And when I left Detroit and went away to school, the first gig I had on the road was at a club at Detroit that's called the Club Saturn, with Chico Hamilton's band; and cross town was Ahmad Jamal's band and about eight blocks away was T-Bone Walker, the great blues guitarist, and of course the local musicians always had four or five little small places to play so jazz was really alive and well. We're talking about '55 through probably '65, '70. You know for fifteen years or twenty years or so it was a really a hotbed of jazz activity.

MR: How about at Eastman? Was there a recognized jazz program at Eastman when you were there?

RC: No. They recognized the music but didn't have a program.

MR: But you were playing bass in the orchestra.

RC: In the Eastman Philharmonic I was the first African American in the orchestra, and when they put together what's now known as the Eastman Philharmonic School Ensemble, it was composed of the better players of the school at that time, that would be my last year, '58, '59; and when they put together the first student ensemble I was the first bassist in that orchestra. No, but jazz wasn't recognized, it really wasn't taught as part of the school academic program.

MR: Wasn't there a Pythod Room?

RC: I started the process there, yes, over on the — way across town from the school, the physical location. And I'd play there two or three nights a week or go out to Syracuse or Utica. There's a trunkline — at that time — a trunkline from Canada to New York, which is kind of on the Thruway, because of the Thruway route. Utica, Little Falls, Herkimer, Syracuse, Rochester, Buffalo and it ends in New York. And so I'd be making gigs up there in most of the towns on weekends, and driving back to school for an eight o'clock theory class Monday morning.

MR: It's an accomplishment that you made it through that kind of schedule.

RC: Well you don't think it's difficult, it's the only way to get it done.

MR: How did your professors feel about that? Or wasn't it even an issue for them?

RC: Well most of them didn't really care. I went to class on time and did the homework. Some of them didn't care for that kind of music so they didn't like what I did in classes, and the school did not encourage a jazz profile. And the strange thing is at that time there was the Eastman Theater, there was a show called "Jazz for Moderns" that would travel throughout the country. And they played at the Eastman Theater, it was a wonderful auditorium, it seated maybe 2,000 people. And they had great bands going all through Rochester. And there was a place called the Ridgecrest Inn, where singles would work, and I remember Sonny Stitt as a sideman and I saw Horace play there with Art Farmer and Clifford Jordan and I saw Dizzy Gillespie's band, I saw Carmen McRae's band, I saw Oscar Peterson's band. And for all the music in the town it seemed pretty strange that they would not acknowledge its existence. And at this "Jazz for Moderns" show that traveled down this same New York State Thruway, line, the show was Lambert, Hendricks and Ross, The Dave Brubeck Quartet, Maynard Ferguson Big Band with Wayne Shorter and Slide Hampton, and Miles' band with 'Trane and Philly and Paul, and Red Garland. So when you have that kind of music in town, with people who are THE

force in music, it's hard to understand how a classical institution would continue to ignore its presence.

MR: Right at that time, when you were about to graduate from Eastman, what were your career aspirations then?

RC: Well I thought that making gigs is one thing, you know twenty bucks a night and you play your brains out and have a great time, but I wasn't sure that that's what I wanted to do. And seeing what appeared to be a relatively stable financial environment as classical orchestral playing, I said well I'll spend four years here and this is my last two weeks at school I might as well find out what the deal is. And Leopold Stokowski, who was one of the guest conductors of the Philharmonic when I was there, took me aside when he was there for the one week, on the last day — it was like a four week — four day week. He would conduct four days and play the concert that night. And that's how they brought in some great conductors with this Eastman Philharmonic Orchestra. And he said he'd like to have me with his orchestra down in Houston, but that he thought that the Board of Directors weren't ready to have a black person in the orchestra. And if this what they're telling him, and he's a major conductor, and they were one of the major orchestras, I mean, really. And he was blunt, he laid it right out. And to this day, if you look at the major orchestras, they still haven't made a dent in the African American music/musicians' scene. New York maybe has one, maybe Cleveland has one, Detroit maybe has one, Chicago maybe has one maybe not. I mean the music hasn't — they haven't shared the musical wealth of people.

MR: And the young black musician nowadays is not going to be encouraged to go that route anyway.

RC: Why would they be encouraged man? I mean the Philharmonic in New York, they go to Abssynian Baptist Church, it's a major church in New York. They go every Thanksgiving and every Christmas. They play one concert and split. I mean if the kids are aware, and they seem to be, they look at the orchestra man and only one of them looks like them, and the orchestra plays and runs. I mean what kind of encouragement is that? So it's a topic that kind of wears me out, and since I've got to go to work I don't want to spend too much time on it. But enough hasn't been said for the African American musician, and hasn't been for as long as I can tell.

MR: New York seemed inevitable for you after Rochester?

RC: Well having done some freelance work at the Ridgecrest Inn club and met some musicians who would talk after the gigs and between classes, they just said New York always has room for a good bass player. I should come to New York and try my hand. So when I graduated in June, I moved to New York in August.

MR: You seem to have had a pretty — it wasn't too long before you were playing with some pretty good people — Chico Hamilton.

RC: Um humm. That was my first gig out of town. I left New York, we left two weeks after coming to New York.

MR: He decided to go west and you stayed?

RC: Eric and I — Eric Dolphy and I stayed in New York, and Chico disbanded, and Chico and the band went to California. The guitar player now is one of the oldest studio guys and the cello player is probably retired, he's probably close to 85 by now, so the band disbanded.

MR: When you were with Miles, I was just looking at some dates today, and I guess I didn't quite realize that you were, everyone in that band was a young man, you were 26 or something like that, and of course Tony Williams was younger and Herbie was about—

RC: 17 so he would be like 24.

MR: It seems amazing now when you look back at the creativity that was going on, and did you guys have a sense that you were kind of — I don't know, making history is a good word, but you had far reaching effects.

RC: I think no. For a couple of reasons. When you're in the middle of this development, you're not able to really step outside and see what's taking place because you're too busy in the development. And the people who were making historical notes, literary notes, they didn't acknowledge the band's impact on music. And that hasn't really happened. There have been some term papers, some theses for doctoral degrees and an occasional three paragraphs in a book, but there hasn't really been the in-depth analogy and acknowledgement that that band was an important band in the annals of history. And given that time, '63 to '68, when there wasn't the kind of critical acclaim that some other people may have gotten, and because we were in the middle of this evolving situation and developing music, no one I think realized that it was impactful as it was. We just — one, had a good time playing, we had a good time to spend with dear friends, and a great time playing some good music every night.

MR: Was there any talking about what you were trying to do beforehand or was it evolving as you played?

RC: Well there was conversation inasmuch as we'd say well that didn't work, maybe if we move it over here maybe that would work. Or some of them may question, if we play double time, are we cutting the bars in half or are we still making the bars stay as they are only with eighth notes as being important rather than quarter notes being important. Do we want to change keys? Maybe we're in the wrong key, do we want to maybe not do this? Those kind of general questions were always a part of our conversation. One thing

that helped us develop whatever it is, finally discussed and what was developed, was that we made a small library. We played maybe 15 to 20 tunes for those five years. And because we'd had a chance to play a song in its original form, as often, and get out as much as those ordinary forms and ordinary changes offered us, it gave us a chance to develop a different set of chords based on this kind of historical background of the song that we had played. And I think because we had a smaller library and weren't forced to fight for the notes or fight for the changes or fight for the melodies every night or fight for the form, because the library was small enough to allow us the latitude — we knew this form. We'd been playing this form for a year. So if we make the form go like this we still know that it started out like this and had this one year intense exposure to this tune. So I think that's part of this discussion that we would have. But it wouldn't be through a lab and microscope, say he may take this out.

MR: Was it kind of shock to go from, you know jazz musicians spend a lot of time learning songs with lots of changes and how to negotiate all that and the bop, and then to go and have a tune like "So What," where you have two chords. Was it like, wow, this is really something different?

RC: Well maybe for the musicians of 1959, but by the time '63 had rolled around it had been thrown around enough times at jam sessions and gigs that some people understood what the choices were, and that for as many choices as there were that would eliminate some of them. So for us it was, what are the best ones of the choices, and can we make them sound musical and reasonable every night.

MR: Okay, just to wrap up here. I was looking at a book entitled *100 Best Jazz Albums*, Len Lyons, you're on at least five of them.

RC: Wow.

MR: Maybe to make a quick comment about some of them mentioned.

RC: Okay.

MR: "Four and More?"

RC: That was done at Lincoln Center. People don't realize that Miles was a real civil activist and he would often play for these civil rights fundraisers. And that night was a fundraiser for some civil rights group, I can't remember, NAACP or something like that. We'd been off about four months, and he told us this is a benefit. So maybe I guess I was the spokesperson of the band said, it's a benefit, okay, well why don't you benefit them and let us have our money? And if I decide I want to benefit them I'll give them a share of my salary. And he said he didn't think so. So I said well I've got to go home man. And he says was I serious? I said yes. How do you benefit with our money? And he said okay. And we got paid, then whatever happened happened. But none of us knew it was being

recorded. We didn't know it was recorded until a year after the record was out, so that was a whole other process, a whole other thing on the scene. And that's one of the stories behind that record.

MR: "Miles Smiles?"

RC: The thing I remember about that record was that we had a chance to develop that music on the bandstand. Most of the recorded sounds were just played on the record. Of maybe the 20 records we made, maybe 5 or 8 of them small group records, and maybe 7 songs a record, there was probably 50 songs, maybe 8 or 9 of them got played live to really develop them, and I'm sure the songs on that record didn't really get the development that I wish they could have had.

MR: A couple with Herbie Hancock — "Maiden Voyage" and "Speak Like a Child."

RC: Well I'm sorry he doesn't really like "Speak Like a Child" anymore, because they were really fabulous. They really showed his ability to encapsulate an emotion with more than three players. But for whatever reason he decided that he's done that already. He's gone on to other things that are just as interesting and productive. To me, there's a chance to play some really well written music by a guy who I'm really close to. And I regret that he hasn't done more of that. "Maiden Voyage" was fun. We rehearsed it two days at a rehearsal hall and went to the studio and made the record in one day.

MR: Someone said you've played on about a thousand records.

RC: Over two thousand.

MR: Over two thousand, so—

RC: I've been busy. Somebody's got to do it, man.

MR: Right. Thanks for your time. I know you have to go put some music together—

RC: I'm going to work on it right now.

MR: for the next set. And best of luck with your Brazilian project that you were telling me about.

RC: Thank you.

MR: And I appreciate your sneaking up here for some time.

RC: I'm sorry I missed you yesterday, but now that's squared away.

MR: Okay.

RC: Thank you very much.